



SUPPORTERS holding action figures based on President Nicolás Maduro rally Sunday in Caracas, Venezuela.

After Maduro, a common refrain: The oil is ours

CARACAS, Venezuela — Like many other Venezuelans, Ramón Arape said the image of ex-President Nicolás Maduro in U.S. custody was a stunning — and welcome — sight. “I confess that I felt a sense of relief when I saw the photo of Maduro in the hands of *los gringos*,” said Arape, 59, a welder and father of three.

Less reassuring, however, were President Trump’s comments about Washington’s determination to take over the government and the oil industry, the nation’s defining natural resource.

“We’ve already had it with outsiders — Cubans, Iranians, Chinese — and now the Americans come along

Some express relief over their leader’s ouster, but there’s an overriding resolve that their country’s natural riches are not for outsiders

By Mery Mogollón and Patrick J. McDonnell

and want to name leaders and sell our oil?” said Arape, referring to a series of foreign allies sought out by the socialist governments of Maduro and his predecessor, the late Hugo Chávez. “It’s a violation of law and sovereignty.”

Many Venezuelans are hoping for a deliverance, but not, it seems, at the cost of selling off the country’s riches. How that plays out with Trump’s view that Venezuela “stole” a U.S.-built oil industry is one of the big questions as Washington embarks on a massive nation-building endeavor in South America.

Like many other nations, Venezuela nationalized its oil industry in the [See Venezuela, A4]

U.S. clarifies plan to ‘run’ Venezuela with pressure

Trump expects interim leadership to yield to American demands

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Top officials in the Trump administration clarified their position on “running” Venezuela after seizing its president, Nicolás Maduro, over the weekend, pressuring the government that remains in power there Sunday to acquiesce to U.S. demands on oil access and drug enforcement, or else face further military action.

Their goal appears to be the establishment of a pliant vassal state in Caracas that keeps the current government — led by Maduro for more than a decade — largely in place, but finally defers to the whims of Washington after turning away from the United States for a quarter-century.

It leaves little room for the ascendance of Venezuela’s democratic opposition, which won the country’s last national election, according to the State Department, European capitals and international monitoring bodies.

President Trump and his top aides said they would try

to work with Maduro’s hand-picked vice president and current interim president, Delcy Rodríguez, to run the country and its oil sector “until such time as we can do a safe, proper and judicious transition,” offering no time frame for proposed elections.

Trump, Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem underscored the strategy in a series of interviews Sunday morning.

“If she doesn’t do what’s right, she is going to pay a very big price, probably bigger than Maduro,” Trump told the Atlantic magazine, referring to Rodríguez. “Rebuilding there and regime change, anything you want to call it, is better than what you have right now. Can’t get any worse.”

Rubio said that a U.S. naval quarantine of Venezuelan oil tankers would continue unless and until Rodríguez begins cooperating with the U.S. administration, referring to the blockade — and the lingering [See Caracas, A6]

Intelligence chief has yet to comment

Tulsi Gabbard’s silence has surprised some, but she once argued against “regime change wars.” **WORLD, A4**

Congress returns, to war powers clash

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — Lawmakers are returning to Washington this week confronting the fallout from the stunning capture of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro — and familiar complaints about the Trump administration deciding to bypass Congress on military operations that have led to this moment.

Democratic leaders are demanding the administra-

tion immediately brief Congress. Republican leaders indicated over the weekend those plans are being scheduled, but some lawmakers expressed frustration Sunday that the details have been slow to arrive.

President Trump told the nation Saturday that the United States intends to “run” Venezuela and take control over the country’s oil operations now that Maduro has been captured and brought to New York to stand trial in a criminal case

centered on narco-terrorism charges.

The administration did not brief Congress before the actions, leaving Democrats and some Republicans expressing public frustration with the decision to sideline Congress.

“Congress should have been informed about the operation earlier and needs to be involved as this situation evolves,” Sen. Susan Collins (R-Maine) said in a social media post Saturday.

Appearing on the Sun-

day news shows, Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer and House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries, both New York Democrats, ticked through a growing list of unknowns — and laid out plans for their party to try and reassert Congress’ authority over acts of war.

“The problem here is that there are so many unanswered questions,” Schumer said on ABC’s “This Week.” “How long do they intend to be there? How many troops [See Congress, A8]



PETE Hegseth, left, John Ratcliffe and Marco Rubio meet with President Trump on Venezuela operations.

How AI is being used in the college admission process

By JAWEED KALEEM AND JOCELYN GECKER

When prospective Caltech students applied in the fall for early admission, some faced a new, technologically advanced step in the selection process at one of the nation’s most prestigious universities.

High schoolers who submitted research projects appeared on video and were interviewed by an artificial intelligence-powered voice that peppered them with questions about their papers and experiments, akin to a dissertation defense. The video-recorded exchanges were then reviewed by humans — faculty and admissions officers — who also evaluated test scores, transcripts and personal statements.

Students applying to college know they can’t — or at least shouldn’t — use AI to write their college admission essays.

So it might come as a surprise that some schools are using artificial intelligence to read them and are incorporating AI into their own admissions process to conduct interviews and detect

fake applications attempting to steal financial aid money.

In some cases, colleges are quietly slipping AI into their evaluation work, while others are touting the technology’s potential to speed up their review of applications, cut processing times and perform some tasks better than humans.

“We wanted to bring the student voice back into applications,” said Ashley M. Pallie, the dean of undergraduate admissions at Caltech, where VIVA, an AI-assisted technology developed by a company called InitialView, helped screen roughly 10% of recent early applicants.

“It might seem strange to use AI to get more of a human voice, but I think of it as a way to bring more authenticity into the fold,” said Pallie, who said the university is planning to expand its use of AI in admissions in 2026.

Colleges stress that they are not relying on AI to make admissions decisions but using it instead to review components of applications, including research projects and transcripts, as well as to eliminate data entry tasks. [See AI, A8]



Rams win, but Chargers fall

Matthew Stafford and Rams go to Carolina, while the Chargers travel to New England for playoffs. **SPORTS, D1**

Hollywood’s script for 2026

We look at the biggest storylines and make a few predictions, including a new leader at Disney. **BUSINESS, A11**

Insightful reads on the age of AI

Eleven essential books to help make sense of a turbulent landscape. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

A passing shower. L.A. Basin: 63/51. **B5**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



State extends migrant truckers’ licenses, risking federal funds

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

California has delayed its cancellation of thousands of commercial driver’s licenses held by migrants, setting it up for another showdown with Washington.

The Department of Motor Vehicles announced on Tuesday that the 17,000 migrant truck drivers whose licenses had been revoked can now keep them for 60 more days, which could enable the drivers to retake tests and do whatever is necessary to continue working legally.

“Commercial drivers are an important part of our [See Licenses, A12]



BEFORE the DMV extension, the cancellation idled vehicles at Bakersfield’s Roadies trucking company.

Ruling allows teachers to inform parents of child’s gender identity

By HOWARD BLUME

A federal court ruling has affirmed the free speech and religious rights of California teachers who want to tell parents about how their child is expressing gender identity at school, a victory for conservatives and parent-rights advocates that stands to rewrite state

school policies if upheld.

In his late December decision, U.S. District Judge Roger Benitez concluded that federal law allows school employees to notify parents of “gender incongruence.” School staff members, he wrote, are free to make a personal decision to contact a parent with information about the possible LGBTQ+ identity of their child.

His court order also bars school districts from “misleading” parents related to “their child’s gender presentation at school.” School employees are prohibited from “directly lying to the parent, preventing the parent from accessing educational records of the child, or using a different set of preferred pronouns/names when speaking with the parent.” [See Ruling, A10]